

THREAD & FATE

A Rule-Light, Story-First RPG

The d20 doesn't decide what happens — it decides how it happens. The story always moves forward.

Part 1: Core Mechanics

The Core Roll

When the outcome of an action is uncertain and the stakes matter, roll a d20 and add your relevant Trait bonus. The GM sets a Difficulty. Only roll when failure would be interesting — skip the roll for routine tasks.

Formula: d20 + Trait Bonus vs. Difficulty Class (DC)

OUTCOMES		
Roll	Result	What happens
1–9	Failure	The story continues — something unexpected twists it forward.
10–14	Partial Success	You get what you want, at a cost or complication.
15–19	Success	You do it cleanly. Narrate the moment.
20+	Critical	Unexpected advantage — the story opens wide in your favor.

Difficulty Classes

DC 8 — Straightforward Anyone could attempt it — the roll shapes style or cost.	10 + Edge bonus
DC 13 — Challenging Needs skill, focus, or luck. Default for most scenes.	Default DC
DC 18 — Daunting Near the edge of possible. Reserve for pivotal moments.	Pivotal scenes

Sparks — The Story Resource

Players start each session with 3 Sparks. Spend a Spark to:

Re-roll	Roll again and take the better result.
Interject	Add a true detail to the scene ("there's a rope here").
Endure	Ignore one consequence — wound, setback, or cost.

Earn Sparks by: roleplaying a flaw, creating a memorable moment, or making someone at the table gasp or laugh.

Resilience & Harm

Characters have 5 Resilience pips. When harmed, lose one pip. At 0 Resilience, the character is out of the scene — not necessarily dead; the GM narrates what that means. Rest to recover 1–3 pips.

Narrative harm — shame, trauma, a burned bridge — is tracked as a Wound Word: a short phrase that acts as a situational penalty at the GM's discretion.

Part 2: Traits, Skills & Character Creation

The Four Traits

Traits are rated 1–5. Add the bonus to every relevant roll.

Bonus = Score – 3 (1=–2, 2=–1, 3=+0, 4=+1, 5=+2)

Body Physical	Strength, endurance, physical presence. Fighting, climbing, resisting harm.
Mind Mental	Knowledge, perception, cleverness. Puzzles, reading people, memory.
Heart Social	Empathy, courage, force of will. Persuasion, inspiration, willpower.
Edge Reflex	Speed, cunning, adaptability. Stealth, reflexes, improvisation under pressure.

Setting Trait Scores

Distribute 12 points across all four traits at character creation. Min 1 · Max 5 · Do not roll.

A score of 3 is average (+0 bonus). Spread points to reflect your character's strengths and weaknesses. These choices are deliberate — they tell a story about who your character is.

Example: Body 2, Mind 4, Heart 3, Edge 3 (total = 12)

Skills & Proficiencies

A skill is a specific area of expertise tied to a trait. When a skill applies to your roll, add +2 on top of the trait bonus.

Formula: d20 + Trait Bonus + Skill Bonus (+2) vs. DC

STARTING SKILLS

At character creation, each player chooses 3 skills.

Skills are freeform short phrases, each tied to one of the four traits. There are no restrictions on what you can name — as long as it reflects something your character has trained for or lived through.

Body skills:	Swords & shields · Enduring harsh terrain · Grappling
Mind skills:	Ancient languages · Tracking & hunting · Alchemy
Heart skills:	Inspiring speeches · Reading a crowd · Comforting the grieving
Edge skills:	Picking locks · Shadowing a target · Sleight of hand

GAINING NEW SKILLS

Skills can be acquired over time through the following methods:

Milestone	Complete a significant story arc or personal goal.
Training	Spend dedicated downtime training under a mentor.
Experience	GM awards a skill after 3 sessions of consistent, relevant effort.
Bond	A deep relationship unlocks a skill tied to Heart.

There is no maximum — skills accumulate as your character grows.

Part 3: Combat & Statistics

Armor Class (AC)

AC represents how hard you are to hit. Attackers must beat your AC on their roll. Your base AC is 10 + your Edge bonus when unarmored.

Armor Type	AC Value	Notes
Unarmored	10 + Edge bonus	Quick and mobile. Default for most characters.
Light armor	12 + Edge bonus	Leather, padded. Edge bonus still applies.
Medium armor	14	Chainmail. Edge bonus does NOT apply.
Heavy armor	16	Full plate. Edge bonus does NOT apply.
Shield	+2 to any AC	Can be used with any armor type. Held in one hand.

Speed

Standard movement speed is 30 ft. per round in structured scenes.

For narrative play, use abstract zones instead of feet:

Close	Within arm's reach — melee range.
Near	Same room or immediate area.
Far	Visible but requires a full move to reach.
Remote	Out of sight or at extreme range.

Initiative

$$\text{d20} + \text{Edge Bonus} = \text{Initiative Score}$$

At the start of any conflict, every participant rolls. Act in descending order of initiative score.

Ties resolve simultaneously, or by narrative logic — whichever creates the better story moment.

Saving Throws

When a character is exposed to an external threat — not a direct attack — the GM calls for a saving throw. Roll d20 + the relevant Trait Bonus vs. the threat's DC.

Save Type	Defends Against
Body Save	Poison, disease, exhaustion, knockback, physical force.
Mind Save	Illusions, confusion, memory loss, mental domination.
Heart Save	Fear, charm, emotional manipulation, breaking willpower.
Edge Save	Dodging traps, explosions, falls, and surprise attacks.

Conflict — How Fights Work

1. Declare	Each character states their intent for the round.
2. Initiative	Everyone rolls d20 + Edge bonus simultaneously.
3. Resolve	Higher totals act first. Ties are simultaneous or resolved by narrative logic.
4. One Roll	No separate attack and defense — one roll covers the entire exchange.
5. Outcomes	Fail: lose a Resilience pip. Partial: both sides pay a cost. Success: achieve intent. Critical: gain advantage.

The GM's Golden Rules

1	Never let a roll end the story — failure is a plot twist, not a door slamming shut.
2	Ask players questions: "How do you do that?" and "What does it cost you emotionally?"
3	Say yes to details players add, unless it breaks the world's internal logic.
4	Skip the roll when the answer is obvious or when failure would be boring.

Advancement

After each session	Add a Session Log entry. Reflect on what changed for your character.
Every 3 sessions	Gain 1 new Skill or raise one Trait score by 1 (max 5).
Story milestone	GM may award a Spark bonus or a special narrative ability.

Character Creation Checklist

☐	Name & Archetype	Who is this person? What role do they play?
☐	World / Setting	Where does the story take place?
☐	Assign Trait Scores	12 points total — min 1, max 5. Do not roll.
☐	Choose 3 Skills	Freeform phrases tied to traits. Each grants +2.
☐	Calculate AC	10 + Edge bonus (unarmored) or use armor value.
☐	Set Speed	Default 30 ft. per round.
☐	Fill Resilience	Start with all 5 Resilience pips filled.
☐	Collect 3 Sparks	Refresh at the start of every session.
☐	Write Personality	A truth about you, a flaw, a drive, and a bond.

Character Sheet

Fill in the fields below. Print or use digitally.

Identity

CHARACTER NAME

PLAYER NAME

ARCHETYPE (E.G. WANDERING SCHOLAR)

WORLD / SETTING

Traits — Distribute 12 points · Min 1 · Max 5

BODY	MIND	HEART	EDGE
Score: _____ Bonus: _____	Score: _____ Bonus: _____	Score: _____ Bonus: _____	Score: _____ Bonus: _____

Combat Statistics

ARMOR CLASS (AC)

INITIATIVE

SPEED

HIT POINT MAXIMUM

CURRENT HIT POINTS

TEMPORARY HIT POINTS

HIT DICE

WOUND WORDS (NARRATIVE HARM)

Resilience & Sparks

RESILIENCE PIPS — cross off when lost, restore on rest

☒ ☒ ☒ ☒ ☒

SPARKS — cross off when spent, refresh each session

☒ ☒ ☒

Death Saves

SUCCESSSES

☐ ☐ ☐

FAILURES

☐ ☐ ☐

Attacks & Actions

Name	Trait	Notes / Damage

Saving Throws

BODY SAVE Proficient? ☐ Bonus: ____	MIND SAVE Proficient? ☐ Bonus: ____
HEART SAVE Proficient? ☐ Bonus: ____	EDGE SAVE Proficient? ☐ Bonus: ____

Skills

☐ ____ Acrobatics	Edge	☐ ____ Medicine	Mind
☐ ____ Animal Handling	Heart	☐ ____ Nature	Mind
☐ ____ Arcana	Mind	☐ ____ Perception	Mind
☐ ____ Athletics	Body	☐ ____ Performance	Heart
☐ ____ Deception	Heart	☐ ____ Persuasion	Heart
☐ ____ History	Mind	☐ ____ Religion	Mind
☐ ____ Insight	Mind	☐ ____ Sleight of Hand	Edge
☐ ____ Intimidation	Heart	☐ ____ Stealth	Edge
☐ ____ Investigation	Mind	☐ ____ Survival	Body

Starting Skills (choose 3 at creation)

SKILL DESCRIPTION	TRAIT

Personality

A TRUTH ABOUT YOU

A DRIVE OR GOAL

A FLAW OR WOUND

A BOND (PERSON / PLACE / THING)

Proficiencies, Languages & Equipment

OTHER PROFICIENCIES & LANGUAGES

EQUIPMENT & INVENTORY

Character Details

AGE

HEIGHT

WEIGHT

EYES

SKIN

HAIR

CHARACTER APPEARANCE

CHARACTER BACKSTORY

Allies & Organizations

ALLY / ORGANIZATION NAME

RELATIONSHIP

SYMBOL / CREST DESCRIPTION

GOALS OR AGENDA

NOTES ON ALLIES

Additional Features & Traits

FEATURES & SPECIAL ABILITIES

Skills Acquired (ongoing list)

SKILL	TRAIT	SKILL	TRAIT
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Treasure & Equipment

CP	SP	GP	PP	EP

EQUIPMENT NOTES

Session Log

WHAT HAPPENED THIS SESSION? WHAT CHANGED FOR YOUR CHARACTER?